

*MY DOUBTS ABOUT FUTURES*

LEAVING MY OWN INVESTMENTS ASIDE, SEVERAL PERPLEXING questions about futures and options needed to be answered. For one thing, if 90 percent of the investors were losers, and this was a zero-sum game, then where did all the money go? I asked around Chicago, and began hearing the same handful of names: Richard Dennis, Ray Friedman, Joel Greenberg, Aaron Itken, Barry Lind of Lind-Waldock, Leo Melamed, and Joe Ritchey. I tried to contact these people, but either they were out of town, on their way out of town, otherwise engaged, or else they simply refused to talk to me.

Richard Dennis was well known for having made millions in commodities and for giving some of it to liberal causes. I considered myself a liberal, but his refusal to be interviewed sent me directly to his counterpart on the conservative side, Joe Ritchey. Little was known about Mr. Ritchey's politics, since he kept a low profile, but he was rumored to be a religious fundamentalist.

I heard other rumors about Mr. Ritchey, as follows: Ten or fifteen years ago, he was a sheriff's deputy in DuPage County, Illinois, presumably making a few thousand a year. He and his brother-in-law started a commodity trading firm which had since made them multimillionaires. It was called Chicago Research and Trading (CRT), and had become one of the largest futures and options firms in the world. CRT had 400 employees, occupied two entire floors of the Chicago Board Options Exchange building, and was about to expand to a third. There was an in-house industrial psychologist, a computer system that rivaled NASA's, a cafeteria that served fresh salmon, and a private gym. Mr. Ritchey and